

Anatomy of a hook

Week 2, Lecture 1 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Why the first line is the only line that matters
- The 210-character above-the-fold constraint
- Five reliable hook patterns
- The difference between curiosity gap and specificity
- Hook-to-payoff alignment

By the end of this lecture you can write five different hooks for any single idea and explain which one you would publish first.

The first line problem

Everything rides on the first line

- X collapses posts to roughly 210 characters before the "show more" cut
- The reader decides to click or scroll in under one second
- Welsh (2022): "The first line is more important than 95% of the rest of the post"
- If the first line fails, the rest of the post does not exist

The first line is not an introduction. It is the entire pitch.

The 210-character window

- On a phone, roughly two short sentences fit above the fold
- On desktop, the threshold is similar: one strong sentence, maybe two weak ones
- The hook must carry all the weight: topic, promise, and reason to care
- Every word above the fold competes for the click; every word below the fold is a reward for earning it

Test every hook by asking: does a stranger stop scrolling for this?

Five reliable hook patterns

Pattern 1: claim

- A direct, declarative statement that makes the reader want to verify or dispute it
- Works because it takes a position, neutral statements produce neutral responses
- Example: "Most creators plateau at 500 followers for one reason: they post topics, not ideas."
- The claim must be specific enough to be falsifiable

Generic version: "Consistency is important on social media."

Specific version: "Posting at the same time every day matters less than posting something worth reading."

Pattern 2: contrast

- Two things the reader expects to be the same turn out to be different
- Or two things the reader expects to be different turn out to be the same
- Example: "The accounts that grow fastest are not the ones that post most often. They are the ones that edit most ruthlessly."
- Contrast creates tension; tension creates curiosity

The contrast must be real, not manufactured. A false contrast reads as clickbait.

Pattern 3: number

- A specific number anchors the promise and signals density of value
- "3 reasons", "7 patterns", "one thing", each sets a different expectation
- Example: "I analyzed 200 threads that went viral. Here is what they all had in common."
- The number must be earned: if you promise ten points, deliver ten sharp ones

Avoid vague numbers: "5 things about writing" is a topic, not a hook. "5 words that kill your first line" is a hook.

Pattern 4: story-open

- Drop the reader into a specific moment before giving any context
- Works because humans process narrative before argument
- Example: "Three months into posting daily, I had 47 followers. I almost deleted the account."
- The moment must be specific: who, when, what happened, no abstract scene-setting

Bush and Cole (2022): "Once they eat the first chip, they're 10x more likely to eat the 2nd, the 3rd, and so on."

Pattern 5: question

- An open question the reader cannot answer without reading the post
- Works when the question is one the reader has actually asked themselves
- Example: "Why do some accounts with terrible writing grow faster than accounts with beautiful prose?"
- The question must have a non-obvious answer; if the reader already knows it, they scroll past

Avoid rhetorical questions that answer themselves. "Want to grow on X?" is not a hook.

Curiosity gap versus specificity

Two ways to earn the click

- **Curiosity gap:** withhold information the reader wants. "The one thing most creators skip."
- **Specificity:** give enough concrete detail that the reader recognizes their own problem. "The one thing most creators skip in month two, when growth slows."
- Curiosity gap alone produces clicks that don't convert to followers
- Specificity alone can feel like a summary, no reason to read on
- The best hooks use both: name the problem specifically, then withhold the answer

Cole (2021): the internet rewards writing that moves fast, not writing that is complete.

Why generic hooks fail

- "Here's what I learned from five years of posting", generic time signal, no specific promise
- "Most people get this wrong", generic target, no identifiable problem
- "This changed everything for me", generic emotion, no transferable idea
- The reader cannot tell whether the post is for them
- Perell (2019): "Write on the Internet and become known for something unique." The hook is where uniqueness first appears.

Each hook must answer: who is this for, and what will they know after reading it?

Hook-to-payoff alignment

What the hook promises, the post must deliver

- A hook is a contract: the reader gives attention, the post gives the promised value
- Breaking the contract destroys trust faster than a bad hook
- Claim hook: the post must prove or precisely define the claim
- Number hook: every promised item must appear and be substantive
- Story-open hook: the story must resolve and the resolution must be the point

Basilio (2023) on Dickie Bush: "The hook of the tweet is the most important part. It's kind of like a YouTube video thumbnail, if it sucks no one is going to keep reading."

Diagnosing misalignment

Common failures:

- Hook promises a counter-intuitive finding; post delivers conventional advice
- Hook names a specific number; post buries the list in three paragraphs of context
- Hook opens with a dramatic story; post abandons the story to make an abstract argument
- Hook asks a sharp question; post answers a different, easier question

Check: read only your hook, then read only your last line. Does the last line answer what the hook asked?

Take-aways

1. The first 210 characters determine whether any of the rest exists.
2. Five patterns cover most of what works: claim, contrast, number, story-open, question.
3. Curiosity gap without specificity produces clicks that do not compound into followers.
4. Hook-to-payoff alignment is a contract; breaking it costs more than a weak hook.
5. Generate many hooks per idea before picking one. The best option rarely comes first.

"The Rate of Revelation is how quickly a piece of writing reveals multiple bits of information that move the reader forward."

Nicolas Cole, *The Art and Business of Online Writing* (2021)

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Hook lab. Twenty hooks, one source claim, peer rating.
- **Reading:** Week 2 reading, Hooks and formats at </c/grow-on-x-26au/readings/wk02>
- **Lecture 2:** Post formats and when each one wins
- **HW1 (Niche and bio):** due this week
- **HW2 (Twenty posts in seven days):** now out